

What is Open Source

Open source – the term has been the centre stage of a David vs Goliath fight in the software community. Be it Windows vs other operating systems, or Internet Explorer vs Mozilla; and now more recently, or more recently Microsoft vs Google. open source has been the rallying point of the so called ‘resistance’ to the proprietary regime. For developers within the software community, open source has transcended the role of a mere development methodology into a core life philosophy. Today, we hear of not just open source software, but also open source hardware, open source biotechnology, even open source politics!

Open source is a methodology or approach towards the design and development of software with the intention of giving the user access to the source code; i.e. if you use open source software, not only will you be able to use it, you will also be able to see how it works, debug it, modify it and redistribute it.

To elaborate and make the difference more clear, imagine the simplest entry level C++ programme, the one that says “hello world.”

If the program was proprietary (non open source), you would merely have access to the EXE file that upon execution would give a window with “hello world” written in it.

However, if the program is open source, you will also be given access to the code that the EXE file is compiled from, namely

```
#include<iostream.h>
void main()
{
    cout<<"hello world";
}
```



The open source initiative